

## Contact


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ResearchGate profile


## Qualifications

**PhD in Philosophy**
UP, 2023
*Ainigma: Plato's Esotericism in Context*

**MA in Philosophy**
UP, 2016, cum laude
*Symphonia: Aristotle versus Plato Critiqued*

**BA Honours in Philosophy**
UP, 2012, cum laude

**BA Humanities: English Literature and Philosophy**
UP, 2010

**PGCE (FET Phase)**
UP, in progress

**TESOL/TEFL Certificate**
120 hours, 2026

## Languages

**English**
Home language

**Afrikaans**
Fluent

# Dr Wehan M. Coombs

*Philosopher and lecturer: Plato, Neoplatonism and esotericism*

## Profile

Philosopher with a PhD from the University of Pretoria and 15 years of university teaching experience, from tutoring to head lecturer. I have designed and taught undergraduate and honours modules, held a postdoctoral fellowship at the University of Johannesburg, and published on Aristotle, Plato and Rorty. My research focuses on Plato, Neoplatonism and philosophical esotericism, and currently on what a Platonic account of learning means for teaching in the age of generative AI. I am also completing a PGCE.

## Academic posts

**University of Johannesburg** Apr 2024 – Apr 2026
*Postdoctoral Research Fellow: Platonic and African Esotericism*

**University of Pretoria, Department of Philosophy** 2010 – 2026
*Head Lecturer (2016 – 2026), Assistant Lecturer (2014 – 2018), Education Assistant (2015), Tutor (2010 – 2013)*

- Head lecturer for first-year, second-year and honours modules, including first-year classes of more than 500 students
- Designed four modules from scratch and partly redesigned a fifth, writing their study guides, and co-compiled a custom reader
- Trained and managed tutor teams, planned lecture schedules and created assessments
- Taught live online and hybrid classes on ClickUP and Blackboard

## Courses designed and taught

- **FIL710/810** Philosophy as a Rite of Rebirth: From Ancient Egypt to Neoplatonism (Honours, 2026)
- **FIL710** The (Secret) History of Thought: Introduction to Philosophical Esotericism (Honours, 2024, 2025)
- **FIL220** The Good Life (2nd year, 2024)
- **FIL110** Introduction to Metaphysics and Epistemology (1st year, 2019 – 2021)
- **FIL251** Introduction to Moral and Political Philosophy (2nd year, partly redesigned, 2018)
- Also taught FIL155 Philosophy of Medicine (2023), BPE211 Ethics (2018), FIL110 (2014, 2017), FIL120 (2014) and FIL251 (2016)

## Research interests

- Plato and the Platonic tradition
- Neoplatonism and theurgy
- African philosophy and decolonial curricula
- Philosophical esotericism
- Philosophy as a way of life
- Socratic pedagogy in the age of AI

## Memberships

Philosophical Society of Southern Africa (since 2017)

International Society for Neoplatonic Studies (since 2017)

## Full resume

Every module taught, all conference papers, the teaching portfolio and student evaluations. Scan or click:

Open the full resume online

# Dr Wehan M. Coombs

## Publications

- Coombs, W.M. 2017. Aristotle's harmony with Plato on separable and immortal soul. *South African Journal of Philosophy* 36(4): 541–552. doi:10.1080/02580136.2017.1385951
- Coombs, W.M. 2013. Contingency, irony and morality: A critical review of Rorty's notion of the liberal utopia. *Humanities* 2(2): 313–327. doi:10.3390/h2020313

## Selected conference papers

- Is Philosophy A(gnostic)? Post-disciplinary Interventions in the Time of Metacrisis. PSSA Annual Conference, University of Cape Town, 2026 (with Mitchell Black)
- Animism, Consilience and the Rights of Nature. South African Society for Environmental Philosophy, North-West University, 2025 (co-presented)
- Reflexive Esotericism: Insights from Literary and Theological Hermeneutics. PSSA Conference, North-West University, 2025
- The Curious Case of Neoplatonic Ritual Magic. PSSA Conference, University of KwaZulu-Natal, 2020
- Immortal and Separable Soul in Aristotle. 42nd PSSA Conference, Rhodes University, 2017
- Twelve conference papers since 2012; the full list is in the full resume

## Research funding

- UJ Postdoctoral Fellowship, Platonic and African Esotericism, 2024 – 2026
- UP Doctoral Support Bursary, Ainigma: Plato's Esotericism in Context, 2018 – 2020

## Service

- Long-time member of Footnotes, the UP philosophy society (2010 – 2025), helping to organise talks and film screenings
- Co-organised the Aristotle Colloquium at UP for Aristotle's 2400th birth year (2016)

## Referees

**Prof. Emma Ruttkamp-Bloem**
Head of Philosophy, University of Pretoria
emma.ruttkamp-bloem@up.ac.za

**Prof. John F. Finamore**
University of Iowa
john-finamore@uiowa.edu

**Dr Asheel Singh**
University of Johannesburg
asheels@uj.ac.za

**Dr Mitchell Black**
University of Pretoria
mblackmitchell@gmail.com